bad for children? People had comic-book burnings, is that right?
My parents never stopped me from reading comics. I did once have to donate some comics to a bonfire in Jackson, Missouri, during the height of that period in my junior high days. I just remember a big pile of them there on the grounds of the parish hall, but I actually managed to sneak home a few from Ziff Davis, whose painted covers appealed to me, such as *Wild Boy Of The Congo* and *Space Busters*.

A lot of companies went out of business. What happened to those that survived?
They got watered down, because if they did anything that wasn't approved of by the Comics Code Authority [an organisation set up to monitor content], they had to change it. So what you got – and what was in place for many years, well into my time and beyond – was self-censorship.

So how did we go from that to the re-emergence of the superhero in the Sixties?
Julie Schwartz at DC helped to revive a bunch of its old superheroes in new costumes, starting in 1956, and Archie Comics had *The Fly* by 1959, so it made sense for Marvel to try it again too. But this time, as he's often said, Stan Lee told Goodman he wanted to do it "his way" – and he was teamed with the equally great Jack Kirby and Steve Ditko, and the three of them changed comics for the better.

It really had that much of an impact?
I bought *Fantastic Four* from issue #1, and there was just something different and offbeat about them and the other characters, Spider-Man in particular. Thor and Ant-Man were less revolutionary – more like DC characters – but they were good too. When I read DC comics, I usually felt that I had to go into the mindset of being a kid again, but with Marvel it was just a little more sophisticated.

You started with the company in 1965, and you had a hand in creating characters. What was that like?
Fun, although I avoided co-creating too many heroes, as I knew I wouldn't own them. Had I known that one day Marvel would arrange a fairer distribution of funds, I'd have created a lot more. But a number of the notions I co-created were done as editor; characters like Wolverine, Brother Voodoo, Werewolf by Night, Man-Thing, Marvel's Dracula, even to some extent Luke Cage. Some were my idea, some were Stan's, and I would develop them and turn them over to a writer. Occasionally, I couldn't resist co-creating a new character – like Iron Fist – or I'd come up with a new character with an old name, like the Vision.

Iron Man was just one of the many characters that Thomas worked on.



> **"WHEN I READ DC COMICS, I USUALLY FELT THAT I HAD TO GO INTO A MINDSET OF BEING A KID AGAIN"**
> ROY THOMAS



Thomas worked on many titles during his time at Marvel, including *Captain America*.

75 Years Of Marvel includes many of Thomas' collected pictures.



ROY WONDER

We take a look at the career highlights of Roy Thomas, the comic-book legend



THE KREE/SKRULL WAR *AVENGERS* #89-97 (1971)
The Avengers intervene in a cosmic battle between the Skrull and Kree races, with Sal Buscema, John Buscema and Neal Adams providing the art for a truly epic storyline.



A MONSTER CALLED... MORBIUS *AMAZING SPIDER-MAN* #101-102 (1971)
Thomas was the first writer to work on the main *Spider-Man* book other than Stan Lee, with his first issue addressing why Peter Parker had grown four extra arms.



THE SONG OF RED SONJA *CONAN THE BARBARIAN* #24 (1973)
After introducing Conan to comics, Thomas was able to add creator Robert E Howard's female warrior Red Sonja, who would later spin off into her own solo series.